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9 PSLE English Oral Exam Tips

The PSLE English Oral Exam tests a student's ability to read and speak fluently. It makes up 15% of the total PSLE English score and consists of 2 components, Reading-aloud (10 marks) and Stimulus-based Conversation (20 marks). 5 minutes of preparation time will be given before the student faces the examiner, and the actual exam should take about 10 to 15 minutes.

The PSLE Oral is one of the English segments that causes the most anxiety for students. Having to read aloud and speak in front of stern-looking examiners puts pressure on shy students.

Hopefully, with these tips, you can prepare yourself for the oral exam and relieve some of the anxiety.

Reading-aloud

For this section, students will be given a passage to read aloud. You will be tested on your fluency, articulation and pronunciation. Furthermore, you need to be able to read with the appropriate emotion and pacing in order to engage the examiner.

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1. **Listen to yourself read**

Even though our voices sound strange to our ears, there is no better way to spot our speech errors than listening to a recording of ourselves.

We can find out whether we are reading a passage too fast or too slow and pick out which words we tend to slur. These are things that we don't pay attention to when we are talking to friends and family.

Take note of how much emotion and rhythm you put into your voice. Remember, you don't want to sound robotic and monotonous.

Oral exam practice usually requires a mentor, a teacher, or a tutor to help you. If no one is free to help out, then recording and listening to yourself read is the way to go.

2. **Practise reading words with difficult pronunciation**

Find lists of words that are hard to pronounce. Find out how to say them and repeat them out loud until you get them right.

If you come across a word you are seeing for the first time, search up both its definition and pronunciation. The way it is pronounced may be completely different from what you think.

Be mentally prepared that you will encounter some hard-to-pronounce words in the oral exam. If the word is long, break it up into its syllables and recite it part-by-part. During the 5 minutes practice, repeat that tricky word a couple of times until you feel confident and it sounds natural. When you reach that word during the actual exam, read it as if you are absolutely sure you are pronouncing it correctly.

Many students freeze when they encounter a difficult word. One stumble may cause you to keep tripping up. Hence, worsening your performance. Even if there are words you don't know how to pronounce, do not stutter, mumble or skip over it. The important thing is being fluent and maintaining your pace of reading.

3. **Remember to hit pause**

Reading like a non-stop bullet train only exposes how nervous you are. Always keep in mind that you should pause when there are full-stops, commas or paragraph breaks.

The length of a pause depends on the punctuation used. Take a shorter pause when you see a comma, and a longer pause for a full-stop or a paragraph break. The different pauses help give rhythm to your reading.

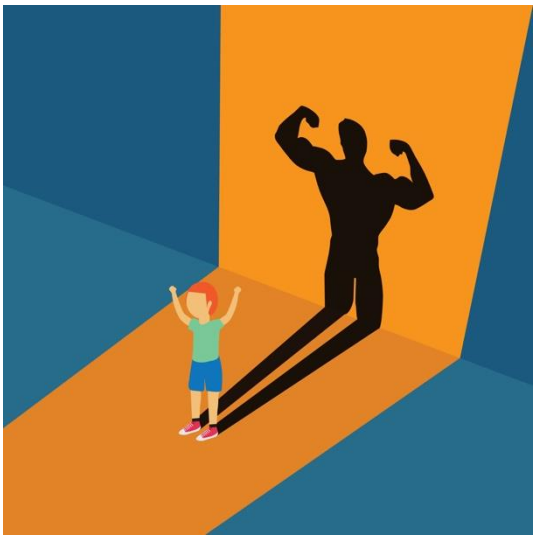
Pausing will give you time to breathe too. You do not want to feel breathless halfway while reading. When out of breath, you can end up either reading too quickly or disrupting your own reading flow by taking in a breath mid-sentence. The punctuations are there to break up blocks of text, so make use of them to pause and breathe.

4. Vary your intonation

Vary your intonation as you are reading, especially if the passage contains dialogue.

Raise your volume a little if there is an exclamation point. You can even read it in a quicker pace if the text suggests rushing. Take note of adjectives or adverbs and channel the emotions into your voice as the passage dictates.

During the preparation time, pay attention to the sentences that end with a question mark. Sometimes, we can get so lost in the text that we forget to change our intonation for questions.



5. Be Confident!

Make sure you sit up straight and keep your chin raised. Don’t read to the piece of paper, read to the invigilator. Your posture and the direction of your voice will make you look and feel more confident.

You want your voice to be as clear as possible, so avoid mumbling. If you notice your jaw clenching in anxiety, take a deep breath and relax. Sip some water to moisten your throat. You don’t want to have to clear it abruptly during the oral exam.

Stimulus-based Conversation

Along with the passage they have to read aloud, students will be given a visual stimulus to study during the 5 minutes of preparation. The examiner will ask questions about the topic of the stimulus, which could be an advertisement, a photograph, a pamphlet, etc.

You should be able to understand what the stimulus is trying to show, but the questions may not necessarily test your interpretation of it. Rather, the Stimulus-based Conversation should feel like two people chatting about a topic related to the picture in front of them.

For example, if the stimulus showed an advertisement for a sports event, the examiner could kick off the conversation with, “Do you like sports?”

6. **Manners and body language**

Speak politely and respectfully. Yes, you should feel like you are having a natural conversation with the examiner. However, they are still your examiners, not your close friends. Don’t make the mistake of peppering your speech with informal slang or Singlish.

Maintain eye contact with the examiner but do not stare. It will engage the examiners better and eye contact makes for a better two-way conversation.

Finally, sit up straight and avoid fidgeting. Sitting up straight helps you project your voice. Make sure you aren’t flapping your hands or gesturing too much as it may be distracting.

7. **Prepare for the questions**

During the preparation time, try to think of questions the examiner may ask you and get your answers ready. Even if your predictions do not turn out right, the points that you have prepared could be relevant to the actual questions.

Typically, the questions will be on the main subject of the stimulus. The first question will ask for your personal opinion and feelings. The follow-up questions will prompt you to think more broadly. For example, it could be your opinion on how other people view the subject and why you think so. Let's take a look at more examples of questions.

If the stimulus is an advertisement about a charity run…

First question:

- Would you like to participate in an event like this? Why?
- Have you participated in a charity event before? Describe it.

Second question:

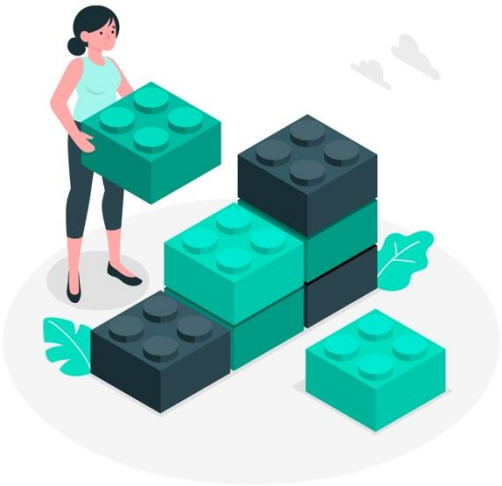
- What are the benefits of participating in the charity run? Why?
- What are some reasons why people will participate in this event?

The third question is normally more difficult and requires you think deeper. Third question:

- What are some charity events that you would like to participate in? Why?
- Why is it important that we participate in charity events such as this?
- Do you have ideas for charity events that could help your community?

The examiner will expect you to explain your opinion, so be ready to elaborate on the "why"s and "how"s of your answers. You should try to relate your opinion to the information from the stimulus as well. It is there to help guide the conversation, after all.

Show the examiner that you are aware of basic current affairs. Don't be afraid to share your opinions and feelings even if you are not sure you are correct. There is no right or wrong answers. As long as you are able to elaborate and explain yourself, you should confidently say what you want to say.



8. **Organise your thoughts**

Nervousness tends to scramble our thoughts. Our words may come out incoherently. If you ever find yourself in that situation, hit pause, take a breath and try to organise your points. It is better to pause mid-sentence to gather your wits than ramble and waste your time.

A simple structure to follow is PRES (Point, Reason, Example, Summary). State your opinion, give the reason, followed by an example to support the reason, and finally reiterate your point. For example:

"Yes, I would like to participate in an event like this. (Point) It gives me a chance to help my community. (Reason) The more people participate, the more money will be raised. If it becomes a big event with lots of participants, more people will pay attention to it too. This can help raise awareness for the charity. (Example) Every person counts, so I want to participate and be part of something positive. (Summary)"

You can also use connectors and transition words.

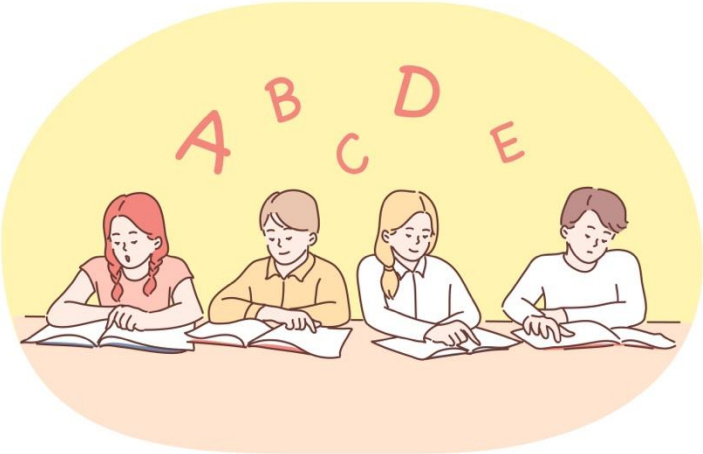
For your own opinions, you can use:

- Personally...
- In my opinion...
- I feel that…

To follow up on your thoughts, you can use:

- Also...
- Secondly... Thirdly…
- Next... Finally…

These signposts not only give structure to the information in your head, they also help the examiner keep track of what you are saying.



9. Use the appropriate vocabulary

Build your vocabulary so you can use precise and descriptive words. Lots of us have opinions that we cannot express because we do not have the right words. We end up trying to explain ourselves over and over again but to no avail.

For example, saying you feel “happy” about something may not accurately describe your feelings. Consider synonyms like “excited”, “enthusiastic”, or “elated” to better suit the context of what you are talking about.

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Final Words

Well, we never run out of things to talk about when chatting with friends. Then why do we suddenly find ourselves tongue-tied in front of the examiner? There are many reasons, of course – nerves, the tense atmosphere, or words and topics we seldom come across in our day-to-day conversations.

The PSLE English Oral Exam is not a walk in the park. Take the time to practice. Try reading passages aloud when you are doing comprehension exercises. Keep asking yourself “why” to develop your own opinions, so you have things to talk about during the oral exam. Finally, be confident about your own thoughts and ideas.

All the best!

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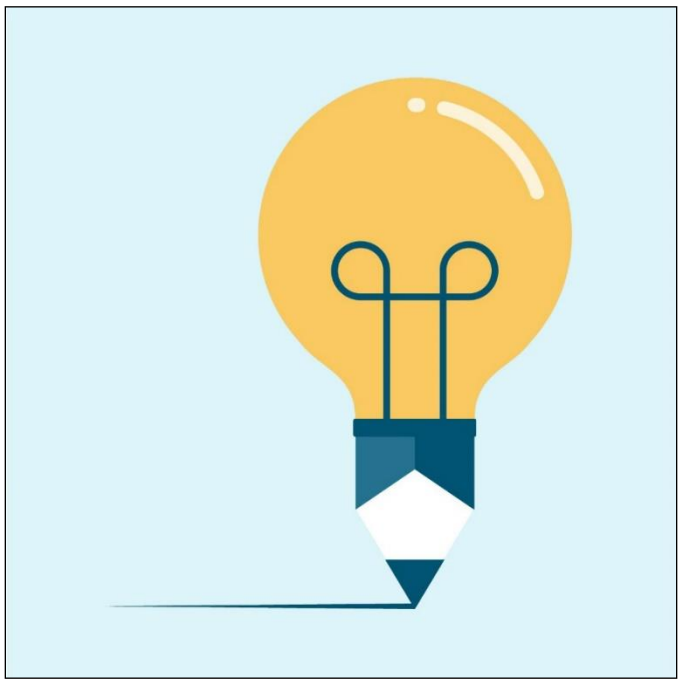

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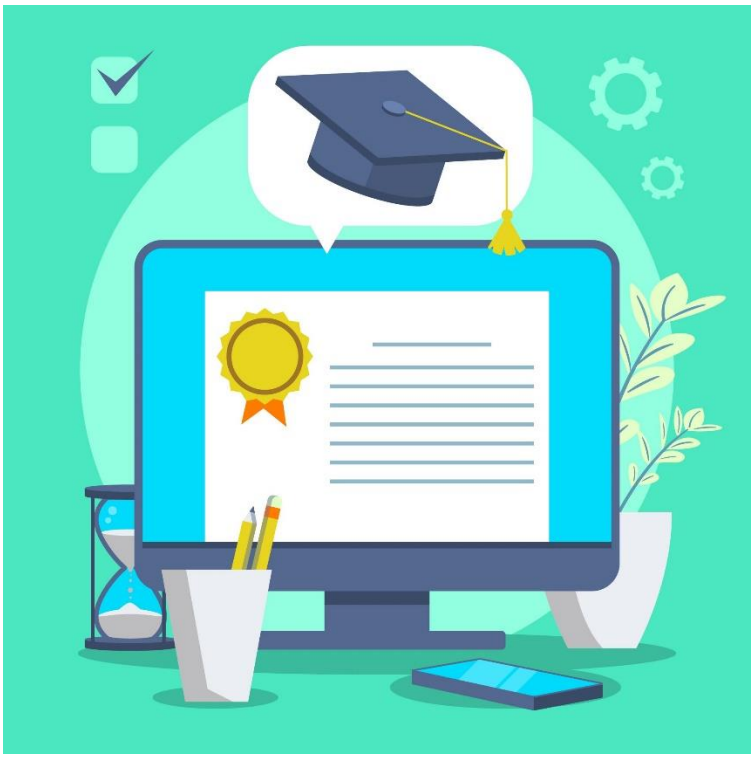

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